"I am my brother's keeper. It's our duty as a citizen of the world to help those that are around us. It's just the right thing to do."

BMNJ was born in Manhattan in 1954 but grew up in Harlem, surrounded by a strong and thriving Black community. His parents were involved in community activism and politics in Harlem. His desire to get involved in community matters started from a very young age and only grew stronger with age. He moved to New Jersey thirty-four years ago, where he continues to be politically and socially involved. Most of his activism is through the NAACP, where he is a formal member and has received various awards for his work. However, informally, he helps organize community groups that want to get involved with voter registration, block cleanups, and other civic activities. He attributes his commitment to helping others to his upbringing and faith and considers civic participation "a way of life."

Below are BMNJ's stories in chronological order.

"Stand up for your rights!"

I was raised in Harlem. We grew up in a community with a lot of very prominent African Americans in the Harlem community. There was always something going on in the Harlem community, people protesting for rights about the school, education, jobs, city services. Harlem was such a thriving community. It was a thriving metropolis for Blacks.

When I was younger, my grandfather had sent me to Baptist Church. That was at Clayton Powell Jr.'s church. He was very much an activist in the Harlem community. The main shot of district for Harlem then was 125th Street, the major stores were white-owned, and blacks were restricted from going there. A lot of stores did not employ blacks in the neighborhood. The community didn't benefit from these shops there. Then Adam Clayton Powell got a movement going that if they wanted Blacks to shop in the store, they needed to employ us and support the community. He was organizing marches along 125th Street. My parents were part of his church, so they were activists in the movement.

Adam Clayton Powell Jr. was a very prominent reverend in the Harlem community. It was a very big church, and he later became a congressman. He organized these marches. The main target that Adam Clayton Powell chose was the store called Blumstein's. It was the major department store on 125th. It was the Harlem equivalent of Macy's. It was a very good store, and everybody shopped there. When Adam Clayton organized this march, my parents got involved. My first indication is what it was, stand up for your rights!

"This was just a way of life for us, serving our community."

As we're growing up, we're serving. It was like upper-middle-class apartments that I was raised in. We had gardens there. It was our duty to maintain the garden. We used to rake leaves and turn the soil. All this is a means of giving back to your community, serving your community.

At the church I went to, there was always something where we made meals for the people that were struggling who couldn't come to church. They would give you the place and say, "Go take this to Ms. X around the corner." This was just a way of life for us, serving our community. If there was an area in the community that- let's say, the garbage accumulated in. Somebody would say, "Let's organize a cleanup." We would get out there with brooms and clean our neighborhoods. It was our duty to maintain our neighborhoods. All this is service to your community, and it becomes second nature. When you saw some older woman coming home with grocery bags, you'd better say, "Hold on, Ms. X. I'll carry that bag for you." You were learning service.

When you're young and going through it, you're not understanding why am I doing this. Why there's a block cleanup? You realize the reason for the block cleanup is because the City Department of Sanitation isn't coming through to clean the block up. You don't learn this at the time, but by doing this service, as I got older, this is when I started to make the connections, though. The service that I do now is what I was raised to do, so I never feel like I'm doing anything special. I'm doing what needs to be done to help my community and my people survive and go further.

I realize now that what we're doing is for survival. In fact, that's what we did for survival, but the children didn't understand that because they learned that this is what you do. Like when you're sitting in the kitchen, and your mother is showing you how to cook an egg, they're teaching how to survive and eat. They're not sitting there teaching you, "Well, you may have to cook for dinner one time, so this is just a survival skill." You learn for your community that these are survival skills you have to do.

Going to school and getting an education is something that you have to do. Learning the trades, to maybe making a living, is something that you have to do. You also have to do something to take care of your sick neighbor or somebody that doesn't have as much for you. If you have something to help them, you just do it.

"I got some more kids my age to come along, and we got on the picket lines."

I was in junior high school or high school. We were trying to get our community center reopened. A lot of the adults wanted to participate. They all said, "Yes. Let's do this. Let's do that." I came along. "Yes, I want in." They was like, "No. You're too young. You're too young." I can remember arguing with them about this. In hindsight, they were probably trying to protect me. To say that this could turn out to be real ugly. Like maybe people getting arrested or beat by police and by governmental forces. They thought I was too young and shouldn't be involved in this kind of stuff. I also understood the rec center they were trying to get open was for people my age, so we stayed involved.

They were going to form picket lines, and they thought that probably there's going to end up being a lot of arrests, and no. I got some more kids my age to come along, and we got on the picket lines just along with them. Fortunately, nothing came about. It was like, "You can't turn us around." I was looking at the civil rights movement. If you look at it, there's always been youth that has been very much involved in things.

"We organized a school bus trip up to Albany where we talked to our state legislators."

When I was in college, we were trying to get college funding expanded. I was very involved in that, with the school movement and writing letters, lobbying politicians, organizing people, "Let's do this," We organized a school bus trip to Albany where we talked to our state legislators. Of course, I can remember that somebody made it where I could go to college. They had programs that funded me to go to college. Had I not found this funding, it wouldn't have happened.

There's programs that they had they called the SEEK program. Many things flowed out of the SEEK program, where you are paying for your books and tuition. In X University, there was no tuition, but even with no tuition, you hardly could afford it. It was like they would pay the tuition for us. I know it's me today, and whoever came behind me, they too needed to get that money, so we fought for them.

"I'm president of the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP)."

I'm president of the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) in the town over. I'm also the first vice president for the state conference of the NAACP, and I also sit on the resolution committee for the national board of the NAACP. We work with students, we have a mentor group, and there's other kids, high school kids, all the way up to adults. NAACP was formed back in 1908 by a multiracial organization. The name is colored people, but I know in my chapter there's a large white contingent; we have Latinos, Asians, and Southeast Asians.

My family has been very much an activist family. I remember being on picket lines about racial injustice. It's something that I've grown up into different organizations but fighting the same fight. Growing up in Harlem, NAACP would have some programs that I've been involved with. It's always been an organization I've been around. I don't remember exactly how I got plugged with them. I was going to some meetings, and then I became a member. I've always done a lot of work with them before I actually signed up and became an active member. I'm thinking it was maybe 25, 30 years ago when I first became an active member.

The work I do with them benefits my community, my town, the town over, and the greater society nationally and internationally. If I was doing something for, let's say, maybe environmental concerns, it'll help the greater society at large and a lot of my civil rights concerns. It'll be a national effect and an international effect.

"I wanted to participate in the primary elections."

I've worked with the politicians to get people elected. That is totally outside of the NAACP hat. I'm a Democratic chair, so I volunteer with the Democratic Party. I support a lot of the Democratic principles, but usually-- For the most part, I do support the Democratic plate because I'm not what you'd call-- I don't vote by party, I vote by people. The Democratic Party tends to be more responsive to my issues and my agenda, so that's who I tend to vote for.

When I joined the active Democratic party, I signed on as a Democrat in the late '90s because I wanted to participate in the primary elections. We had primary elections because there was certain candidates I wanted to push in the primary election. In order to push a candidate, you had to be a member of the party. That's how I formerly ended up joining the party.

"I helped in passing the law because I said something."

When Katrina happened, all these places got flooded out down in Louisiana. I remember, I read there was a bill going through congress that they wanted to get some more funding to re-appropriate money for the families that were devastated by Katrina. Get some more money to get their lives back together. I read that one of our local politicians was not going to sign the authorization for the folks to get that money. It was going to be a close vote, so every vote was needed. When I saw it, I called him [chuckles], "You got to do something about this." He explained to me; he said, "there's a lot of pork in this for this organization to get money donated." He says, "Let's talk about it."

The next day we sat down and talked about it. He showed me the bill and showed me these thousands of dollars would go here for somebody to put a new garbage can there. This one was thousands of dollars to paint a road there. After he explained it all to me, I said, "But look, if this bill doesn't get signed," I said, "Those people don't get the money." I read in the paper the next day that he signed onto it. I tell people how sometimes when they say one person don't matter, yes, one person does matter. I feel like perhaps a family in Katrina got a check because I helped in passing the law because I said something.

It encourages me to keep doing what I do. I've seen I can help. I've had losses [laughs]. Since the last time, I'm going to people like politicians to sign on for this, and it didn't happen, but still you keep going. You keep going, this is what I have to do.

"One man alone can't make the change. There's always people beside you, in front of you, or behind you."

There was two occasions I was down at the Supreme Court. One in 2013 to protect our voting rights. We were down there participating, trying to implore the Supreme Court not to cut Section 4 of the voting rights act, not change anything on the voting on polls, the locations, or the procedures.

This photo was in 2017 when we were talking about DACA. The idea of being in the Supreme Court because the work that I'm doing now is legislative work, trying to legislate policies. The last step of that demonstration tends to be the Supreme Court; that's our final offer where our rights end up. I like this picture of myself and my thoughts. The only other person that fits is the security guard standing in the background by the door at the Supreme Court.

It's just me and my thoughts about how far we have to go to gain our rights. That's why I like that picture. I've been an activist all my life, and this is a culmination of my activism. That's why, whenever I look at that picture, my mind goes back to years and years of doing this kind of work. Also, I'm sitting there alone, but it also reminds me that I'm really not alone. My family supports me, the office in many organizations I work with, they all supported me.

One man alone can't make the change. There's always people beside you, in front of you, or behind you. There's always one person who often ignites the change we're looking to fight for, but you're never alone. We have to advocate the decision, legislation, then litigation. In order to gain, you got to be out there.

The shirt I'm wearing says America's Journey for Justice. It was the NAACP event where they marched from Selma to Washington D.C. We were all talking about the Voting Rights Act. It was a recreation of the journey from Birmingham to Selma. This was a march that went from Birmingham all the way and ended up in Washington, D.C, but it was an NAACP undertaking where hundreds of people marched about 500 somewhat miles up when they did it. I met them at the rally and marched in at the end of it. Of course, it ended at the foot of the Capitol building.

Often, when I talk about my experience and what I'm doing, I try to get people to understand this is a culmination of the work I do. I often talk about that picture or show it to people, so they try and get a sense of what I do and how I feel and my devotion to activism and get a sense of why I'm so passionate about what I'm doing.

"Everybody has something to give."

I know when I was fighting for DACA students. These are people who have been brought here by their parents. By them succeeding, the DACA student you help succeed may be the one that cures the cancer you're going to get. The person you help along the way may be the one to help you. We're different pieces of the puzzle. When I was younger, I had an incident where somebody tried to rob me. They ended up hurting me, and I had to end up going to the hospital. The person who took me to the hospital was what we often refer to as the neighborhood bum. He was the one in the corner, the one they ask you for money. This man saved my life.

It proved the point that everybody has something to give. You realize that these experiences are many. No matter who you are, you can give something. It taught me that everybody has worth, and I can't be the one to judge somebody else's work because you never know.

"I still think I have a critical role in the community because I have the experience."

Often, the adults call themselves protecting the children from getting involved or the youngsters from getting involved, but the youngsters have the energy. That's why I search for youth to get involved because they have the energy.

I can't walk picket lines like I used to or go through marches like I used to. I know these things have to be done. I try to train youth on how to do a march, how to do a picket line, things you must consider, legal consequences. I have a level of expertise where I could impart my knowledge on them to carry on the things I used to do. They will organize a block cleanup. They will see that the senior citizens and shelters in their area are not dismissed and overlooked.

I still think I have a critical role in the community because I have the experience of having done so many of these things. I've raised my children to have this kind of activism code so that they, in their professions and the world, carry on the work. Other youth in my area that I've come in contact with or mentored will carry on this work. It's important that they have a continuum. I've come very far. My people have come very far, but we got so much farther to go. I have to do what I can to train the soldiers, the activist, educators that come behind me, so maybe one day, they be the ones to pick up the mantle and do whatever they can do.

"It restored the right to vote for 83,000 former felons."

Prior to COVID, I've gone to my state legislator, my national legislator, and spoke one on one with Senators, Governors, Congresspeople to lobby on behalf of our (NAACP) causes. Just before COVID shut us down, we were trying to get former felons the right to vote. They were not legally able to vote. We were trying to get them the right to vote. I've done this on the state level. I've gone back to Trenton and talked to our congressional representatives, our assembly representatives, our state representatives. I have gone to their offices and met with them on local sites and explained why we felt they should pass this legislation. They finally passed it. Around the end of February, early March, and it restored the right to vote for 83,000 former felons.

I remember when they passed that voting rights act, giving felons the right to vote. I was down in Trenton at the statehouse when that bill passed and was finally signed by the governor. I've seen guys and women who have come out of jail and worked with us trying to get the right to vote. When Governor Murphy put his name on that paper, I've seen people who were grown men and women be like, "Wow, I can do this." I've seen the tears rolling down their faces. That's how important it was. It meant they can be part of society again.

For so long, they have felt like an outcast and couldn't conform to society. They can't get jobs when they come out of jail. They can't qualify, and they are prohibited from trying to become a part of society. They have no alternative but to fall back into crime. I know people who was going to jail, and I've known people who've done some terrible things. I learned this as a child; my grandfather taught me, some of the people who do bad things aren't bad people. It stuck with me.

In the past maybe six months, I've signed up a few former felons to vote. They're on the phone while you're standing there, and they're calling one of their friends who was in the same position and tell them, "Yes, you know you can vote." It really makes a difference in their life.

"I ride around with voter registrations in my car."

There was a community group that wanted to do some voting registration. I said, "Yes, let's get our community registered to vote." They was looking to get a little more power in their municipal government by showing their voting strength. That's something I do regularly. I ride around with voter registrations in my car. I would say come on, who you have, let's get this done and put it together and just start knocking on doors.

Voting registration is something I do every day. Sometimes with the group, it might just be for a day or evening. We have what they call a voting initiative to get this block registered, and you do it in a day, and that's the end of it.
Often, when I do voter registration, people want to go to church or to schools. I go in the hood and talk to people. From being out there for all these years, you get a reading, somebody that just doesn't want to be bothered, somebody that might want to take your advice. You feel like, well, I'm pulling them back into society.

"We [NAACP] collaborate with the activities the churches in town have."

Here in my town, I've petitioned the government, the police, the governmental administration, schools. Sometimes there's been store merchants that had some racial problems. We [NAACP] collaborate with the activities the churches in town have. They do a lot of work with the immigrant community. I am going to different facilities trying to get people out of the lockup for immigration, former felons, we are trying to do that kind of work. I've done that through the church community.

For example, recently, we went to an immigrant detention center in Elizabeth, where we are trying to get people released. I've gone to the detention center, I've spoken publicly by addressing the "powers that be" that these people should not be held in detention, that they should be let out. Senator Menendez was there, it was like a protest, but it was just to go there and publicly plea. We addressed a crowd that had gathered up there and Senator Menendez. We was asking him to lobby for us by going through official channels. There were some officials from the facility there. I don't know exactly who they were, but they were there also. We just let them know that we didn't think it was right. The church in my town organized it.

"I have skills on how to organize groups."

This past year in the fall, we went down to one of the housing developments out here in the town to get the neighborhood physically cleaned up. That was a local initiative from the community. Members of the community said, "Let's clean up the block and clean up the streets." I knew about it through my social circles. I'm a community activist, a lot of my social circle are also other activists. We don't just go out and march for a cause; we're also friends.

Many people in the community who are not formally associated with any group know I have skills on how to organize groups. These aren't formal groups. You might have people on a block concerned about their community and might want to do something. They'll come together as a unit to do a task. It's not like they're a regular group that meets every week or every month. It might be just an ad hoc community group. I let them know how to do it, getting permits from the city if you need to get them. For a clean-up, you might need some permission from public works. I could tell them how to do that, and they will do it. I have a relationship with some people in the government, so I may ask them on their behalf. I talk to somebody I may know down the public works or the City Hall, and they could make things happen.

"Urging the community to make sure they fill out their census."

Today we did the town in NJ, yesterday we did what they call the day drive-in, and it was a group of people. It was like New Jersey Pride, the Foundation, the NAACP, so maybe five or six different groups. We got together, and we rode through the streets of the town with a bull horn and a parade of cars urging the community to make sure they fill out their census. It was about two hours riding. We went all through the neighborhood and stuff. I said to somebody, "We did all this. If I get one person who decided to fill out the census after seeing us, it's a victory." [laughs]

A lot of community groups were doing the work like I'm doing; that's usually the way it's done. It's not just-- We don't usually have just one group because we're benefiting the neighborhoods, the community, the city, stuff like that. We try to get as many different organizations that will be affected by this to get on board to do this project.

"My thing is to support the younger generation."

My thing is to support the younger generation and understand that they're doing the same work. They might have different tactics, just support them and help them be more effective with their tactics. Let them know that you're not trying to get them to be us. We're trying to help them to be better now because I know a lot of youth. I deal with a lot of youth, and I think that's why I've been able to deal with them, and my wife has been able to deal with them because they see we're not telling them what to do. Just make them better at whatever it is they are doing.

Mentoring is a very vague term because when people think of mentoring, they think it's something where you regularly meet with a person and counsel them in life as they go through. It can just be that one interaction with another person, a child. You give them a little advice, and they take that advice and use it to their benefit. They can remove the mental block or whatever they happen to face.

"I consider myself very much a proponent of Black Lives Matter."

We've (NAACP) done a lot of work with groups within the Black Lives Matter, and we've done pitch-ins with them. We've worked with them in different activities they've done, protest march. We are supporting their cause. I consider myself very much a proponent of Black Lives Matter because just cause we want to focus on Black lives at this time, it doesn't mean that we are negating anything else.

There was a group of high school students organizing for Black Lives Matter. We were very much involved in that. We helped the students organize, spoke at their events, offered them options of people who they might want to include in their conversation. It's funny, there was one young black girl that was doing a program through the NAACP who got me involved. When I got down to the actual event, it was South Asians that were a very large part of this group. I guess anecdotally, I would say they were the majority of the people that organized this event. I was surprised to see that they got it. They understood what the Black Lives Matter movement is. It's talking about equality and justice for everybody, not just Black students. It was very refreshing for me to see this.

"… it gives me hope that maybe I will see a resolution to this."

It's funny, all the stuff you see going on now [reference to BLM], what people are doing now is what I had been doing for years. It's like the rest of the world is finally catching up to this. This is what I've been doing. I'm feeling good because I think it will bring a quicker resolution to the system. You look at lives are still on rights strike, started in 1956. You had *Emmett Till slain,* then you had '57, you had Rosa Parks doing the bus sit-in. '63, you had the march on Washington, then the Civil Rights bill got signed. The next year in '64, the equal rights amendment got signed. Maybe it won't take another 10 or 15 years for these issues to get signed. When I see the ground floor of this, it gives me hope that maybe I will see a resolution to this. I know never in my wildest dreams did I ever think that I will see an African American president. Then it happened.

When he made that speech in Boston before he decided to run, I listened to him, and I knew some people in Chicago that knew him as a community activist. I remember by then saying, "If he does anything to run, I'm going to support him." When he came out formally, I was handing out flyers and making phone calls from day one, anything I could do.

I can remember when Mayor Dinkins was running for reelection; I was very much a supporter of Mayor Dinkins. My family happened to have known each other, and my mother died the weekend before the primary. I was at their house, answering the phone, taking the call. Everybody is calling, giving their condolences. I can remember I was answering the phone at my father's house, and the first thing I would say when I answered the phone was, "Vote for Dinkins," then I would say, "Hello." I was already living in New Jersey at the time, so I wasn't involved in the day-to-day campaign, but anybody I knew in New York I was telling them to make sure to vote for Dinkins. He lost the election, but I was trying to do what I could to get him elected.

"I've missed a lot of family functions."

They say think global, act local. Of course, I want to start with my family and close friends because that's what I happen to be around. That's where I have the most direct effect. It's almost like when you throw a rock in the pond how it ripples out, and that's where I am. I've been fortunate. I have, let's say, as a child, my family was supportive. When I got my wife and family, they've been very supportive and allowed me the freedom to do this. I've missed a lot of family functions. They did want to go on vacation, but I had to go on a march somewhere or do stuff somewhere. They've sacrificed going with me, for that I owe them.

I had a Police Community Relations training I had to go to, and my daughter was having a dance event, and I had to skip that in order to do the training. Of course, your child wants her daddy there and stuff, but because they've been brought up in this environment, she understood. Daddy got to do what he got to do. In this instance, it was about improving law enforcement and community relations. There's always been tension between law enforcement and the community, incidentally for black communities. The training was on how to make that go a little better.

"It's the right thing to do. Somebody did it for me. Nobody made it alone in this world."

I was raised coming up in the streets of New York. My family wasn't poor. We didn't have to worry about eating and stuff, but there was a lot of different social things I benefited from. I've had people help me to get jobs. I've had people help me to get educated where some doors I know might have been closed to me, but I've had to call somebody that they would get a door open—even some access to information.

If I can help somebody vote or help somebody who needs rent or connect them to organizations where they can get rent. It's the right thing to do. Somebody did it for me. Nobody made it alone in this world. Sometimes people say, "I stand on others' shoulders." Yes, I stand on others' shoulders, but I'm looking for somebody to stand on mine. I don't have any preferences in what I do. I just want to help.

I've received plaques and awards and all that stuff. The recognition is nice. I invariably would say that in every speech I do, and I mean it from the bottom of my heart, I said, "This is not for me. I'm just the one out front, but there's a lot of people behind me doing this stuff. I'm just the face, but there's a lot of people out there just doing the work."

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